

THE BAHÁ'Í WEEKLY

Beware of prejudice ; light is good in whatsoever lamp it is burning. A rose is beautiful in whatsoever garden it may bloom. A star has the same radiance whether it shines from the East or from the West.—*Abdul Baha*.

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HIDDEN WORDS

OF

BAHA'U'LLAH

TRANSLATED BY

SHOGHI EFFENDI

(10) O SON OF UTTERANCE !

Thou art My stronghold; enter therein that thou mayest abide in safety. My love is in thee know it, that thou mayest find Me nigh unto thee.

(11) O SON OF BEING !

Thou art My lamp and My light is in thee. Get thee light therefrom and seek none other than Me, for I have created thee rich and have bountifully favored thee.

(12) O SON OF BEING !

With the hands of power I made thee and with the fingers of might I created thee; and in thee have I placed the essence of My light : Be thou content with it above all else, for My work is perfect and My command is binding. Question it not and have thou no doubt.

(13) O SON OF SPIRIT !

I have created thee rich, wherefore impoverish thyself? Noble I made thee, wherewith dost thou abase thyself? Out of the essence of knowledge I manifested thee, why seekest thou any one beside Me? Of the clay of love I molded thee, why dost thou busy thyself with another? Turn thine eyes unto thyself, that in thee thou mayest find Me abiding, mighty, powerful and self-subsisting.

(14) O SON OF MAN !

Thou art My dominion and My dominion perisheth not, wherefore fearest thou thy perishing? Thou art My light and My light shall never be extinguished, why darest thou extinction? Thou art My glory and My glory fadeth not; thou art My robe and My robe shall never be destroyed. Abide then in thy love for Me, that thou mayest find Me in the realm of glory.

(15) O SON OF UTTERANCE !

Turn thy face unto Mine and renounce all else but Me; for My sovereignty endureth and My dominion perisheth not. Wert thou to seek another than Me, surely thou shalt fail, shouldst thou search the universe for evermore.

(16) O SON OF LIGHT !

Forget all else but me and commune with My spirit. This is the essence of My command, turn unto it.

(17) O SON OF MAN !

Be thou content with My self and seek no helper but Me, for none but Me can ever suffice thee.

(18) O SON OF SPIRIT !

Ask not of Me that which thou desirest not for thyself and be content with that which We have ordained for thee, for this is that which profiteth thee, if therewith thou dost content thyself.

INVOCATION

O Lord, deliver us from all temptations, tests, and evil suggestions of those who have turned their faces from Thee, O Thou mericiful God, confirm us by Thine invisible hosts and reinforce us through Thy heavenly angels.

O Lord, we are weak, poor, submissive and humble; strengthen, enrich and uplift us above all earthly conditions.

O God ! As Thou hast illumined our hearts with the light of knowing Thee, make us firm in Thy Blessed Covenant.

Verily, Thou art the clement, the forgiving !

STAR OF THE WEST

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The First Feminist Martyr

By Zeine Nour-ud-Dine Zeine

Mr. Zeine, the author of this valuable article, is a graduate of the American University of Beirut and is now a teacher of sociology in that splendid institution. He has a remarkable background. His grandfather, Jinabi Ziene, left Persia and followed Baha'u'llah first to Baghdad and later to 'Akka' where he spent the rest of his life as one of His amanuenses, so the family first lived in 'Akka' and later in Haifa. We are fortunate to have for the Baha'i Magazine the accurate material which Mr. Zeine has sent us—a picturesque and dramatic account of the tragic story of Qurrat-ul-Ayn, the far-famed Persian Feminist and Poetess, the first woman martyr for the freedom of women. *Star of the West.*

You can kill me as soon as you like, but you cannot stop the emancipation of women" so said the Persian feminist and poetess Quarrat-ul-Ayn when she was imprisoned in 1850.

Born of a noble family, her keen and sagacious intelligence and her fervid eloquence very soon filled all those who came in contact with her, with awe and admiration. Awe, because in her controversies with the most learned men, she was ever triumphant. Admiration because in a time when most of her country women could not read or write, she displayed such marvelous powers of learning and speech.

Her beauty matched her elocution. But it was a grand, a commanding, a majestic beauty. On one occasion it is so related, when she was delivered up to the government authorities, she was brought before the Shah, who, on seeing her, said: "I like her looks; leave her and let her be." On another occasion, the festivities and rejoicing of wedding were going on in the house of one of the Persian nobles. When Qurrat-ul-Ayn came in, the ladies of the court and other distinguished guests who were present were so much attracted by the charm of her looks and so greatly impressed by the beauty of her speech that, "forgetting the festivities, they gathered round her, diverted, by listening to her words, from listening to the melodies, and rendered indifferent, by witnessing her marvels, to the contemplation of the pleasant and novel sights which are incident to a wedding."

It means very little to say that Quarratu'l-Ayn was in advance of her age, unless one says also what that age was. Persia, nay the East in general was in a deplorable state. Ignorance and superstitions prevailed; intolerance and bigotry waxed high. Education was neglected. The rights of women were slighted. Such were some of the conditions during that age. Filled with a passionate desire to change all that situation she raised her voice against it, discussed and debated with doctors and sages, and addressed the meetings of the most eminent men. At the beginning she used to carry on her discussions and talks from behind a curtain, but later she threw aside her veil, thus adding the power of her looks to the potency of her words.

To lay aside the veil and speak in public at a time when "women were secluded in harems and had to be closely veiled if they appeared in public places," when it was considered impolite for them to speak to men, needed a heroic courage. The ideas she propounded endangered her life. Yet her courage never failed her and her heart never recoiled from the oppressions and persecutions that she

received at the hand of her enemies, by day and night, and accompanied by a few who had become inspired by her noble ideas, she traveled in Persia from city to city, pleading with men and women everywhere to abandon their prejudices and superstitions and love truth; to put aside hatreds and jealousies and live in harmony and good will with each other. She championed the cause of education of the both sexes and fought for the freedom and rights of her kind. Her fame now spread far and wide so that "most people who were scholars or mystics sought to hear her speech and were eager to become acquainted with her powers of speculation and deduction."

Finally, the clergymen were alarmed: her vehement and tumultuous ideas confounded them and her courage and steadfastness in spreading those ideas filled them with apprehension. The people were aroused to molest her, and eventually, she was delivered up to the government authorities. It was then that she pronounced those heroic words with which this account begins. She was imprisoned for two years. Then in August, 1852, a disastrous attempt was made on the Shah's life. Many people were arrested, horribly tortured and condemned to death. And she was one of the innocent victims of that fatal day.

Qurratu'l-Ayn met a very painful and lingering death. The story of her execution is a very tragic one. She was delivered over to one of the military authorities—a Sardar—who was made responsible for her execution. In Tihiran "she was placed in the house of the Kalantar, a town official who was made responsible for her custody."

"Three days (the Kalantar's wife related) our beloved guest stayed in her room chanting prayers—eating little and seldom. On the morning of the third day she said to me: "Tonight they will come for me". She gave to me a bottle of attar of roses, a ring, and a handkerchief—her only possessions—all she had left of her former riches."

Another account has it that Qurratu'l-Ayn had put on a snow-white robe of pure silk before her execution. When asked by her guardian, early in evening, why she had changed her dress, "I will be going on a long journey tonight", she had answered. And so by dint of feminine intuition, she had known the time of her death. As the leaden-footed hours of the night were passing one by one and the silence of nature grew deeper, the beginning of that journey was drawing nigh. "Chanting prayers, she waited, waited, prepared and ready for what she knew would come."

And that evening they came.

It was the fifteenth of September,

1852. The lights of the city of Tihiran were going out one by one. People were sleeping. The richly colored domes and minarets of the Capital shone pale in the light of the moon. A sad moonlight was shining through the window of the room where the beautiful Qurratu'l-Ayn was confined. It was a room in the garden of the Sardar near the gates of the city, to which she had been brought that same evening. The stars were so pale and the night was so still, so silent, as if the whole creation was watching breathlessly in dreadful expectation of a bitter and heartrending tragedy.

At about midnight, for the first time, the tranquil silence was broken by the sounds of some footsteps. Presently a key turned in the lock, the door opened slowly, and a handsome young Turk entered the room of Qurratu'l-Ayn. He held a silken handkerchief in his hand. She, sitting on the floor in the middle of the room, was praying. As she moved towards her, she suddenly raised her head, threw at him one of her piercing glances and said in a clear and dignified voice: "Young man, it becomes you not to be my executioner, and to perform such a crime". Horror stricken by those words, the young Turk refused to touch her, turned back, and ran out of the door "like a madman." It is said that he dashed into the room where his master, the Sardar, was awaiting him, flung at his feet the fatal handkerchief and the money he had received as a bribe, and said: "I am ready to kill myself and not shoulder the responsibility of this woman's death."

A few moments later, another person entered the room of the prisoner. He was a heavy set, coarse, ugly looking man. And he was drunk. He held the same handkerchief in his hand. Qurratu'l-Ayn had finished her prayers, but she was still sitting on the floor. As his looks fell upon her, his wolfish eyes flashed with ferocity born half of intoxication and half of his own beast-like nature. Without a moment's hesitation, he threw himself upon the unfortunate young woman and accomplished his dark deed—he strangled her with the handkerchief. There were still signs of life in her when he drew her out of the room. Here he met others who were sent to help him in the accomplishment of the Sardar's feindish scheme. They dragged her to the rim of a dry well and threw her into it. Immediately the well was filled up with large and heavy stones. It was midnight.

The moon had now sunk behind the snow clad Elburz mountains. The shadows of the domes and the minarets grew deeper and blacker. Darkness enveloped the city of Tihiran. There was not any light save the pale glimmering of the lonely stars. As the men were returning from the well, something fluttered on a rosebush near by. Apparently a nightingale disturbed in her sleep. At the same time a loud shrill sound of a cock pierced the appalling silence of the night. Also a wind was growing, "a wind that laid a cold finger upon flesh and spirit". And the leaves that laid without a sound on the trees began to whisper again. It seemed that the creation was beginning to breathe once more; but there was something in that

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